

Transgender, Gender Diverse and Non-Binary Terminology

glossary



supporting your gender journey

Acknowledgement

Transgender Victoria works and organises on land belonging to the Wurundjeri, Boonwurrung, Taungurong, Dja Dja Wurrung, and Wathaurung peoples of the Kulin Nation. Transgender Victoria pays its respects to Elders past, present, and emerging, and acknowledges that sovereignty has never been ceded.

We acknowledge the custodianship of this land's people and the privilege and responsibility to Connect with Country. We acknowledge and honour the unbroken spiritual, cultural and political connection Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples have had to this unique place for more than 2000 generations and the continuation of cultural, spiritual and educational practices of First Nation communities.

We would like to also highlight that our resource draws largely on colonial language, and this may not reflect the way that Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples describe their gender identity and sexuality across 250+ language groups.

First Nations culture have always recognised and involved much more diverse presentations of gender identity that cannot be encapsulated within the social concept of a binary system of gender that has been dictated by Western societies and enforced by colonisation. It is important to respect and acknowledge diverse representations and descriptions of gender identity, especially from our First Nations, BIPOC communities around the world.

Glossary

If you're new to the world of allyship, you might come across some words and terminology that you don't fully understand. In this language guide, we've identified some of the most common terms and their definitions.

Remember, language is constantly evolving, and isn't a one-size-fits-all. Some of these terms are contested within and outside TGD communities. It's always a good idea to check with the TGD people in your life about what language and terms they prefer.

Term	Definition
Agender	A person who doesn't identify with any gender, feeling gender neutral, rejecting the concept of gender or feeling a lack of gender identity.
Affirmation	The act of providing support, validation, and respect for someone's gender identity or expression.
AFAB	A person who is assigned female at birth by medical professionals.
Ally	A person who supports and advocates for a marginalised or discriminated-against group. In this case, trans and gender diverse people.
AMAB	A person who is assigned male at birth by medical professionals.
Androgynous	Used to describe people whose outward gender expression cannot be distinguished between feminine or masculine or have combined traits that are masculine or feminine in nature. Can be a way for some to reach gender euphoria.
Bigender	Where a person experiences two genders as their gender identity. This can mean a combination of those genders, or genders that are felt simultaneously or alternating.

Term	Definition
Brotherboy	A term used by Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people to describe those who are gender diverse that have a male spirit. They take on male roles within the community and have a strong connection to their culture. Nonbinary people may also connect to a Sistergirl if they embody a masculine spirit.
Cisgender	A person whose gender identity aligns with the sex assigned to them at birth.
Deadnaming	The act of using the birth name of a transgender person without their consent, particularly when they have adopted a new name.
Demigender	An umbrella term for people that feel a partial connection to a particular gender (but not fully connected to it). Examples are demiboy or demigirl.
Gender	Different to sex (described below), gender is one's internal sense of self that can consist of social, psychological and emotional traits or behaviours. Gender is a construct made up by societies.
Gender diverse	An umbrella term used to encompass any gender identities or experiences that differ from what people were assigned at birth.
Gender dysphoria	The distress that may accompany the incongruence between one's experienced or expressed gender and their assigned gender at birth. Is the opposite of gender euphoria.
Gender euphoria	The feeling of relief, joy and contentment that arises from experiences that are gender-affirming in nature. Is the opposite of gender dysphoria

"When you know one trans person, you just know one trans person. And the representation of who we are is limitless."

- Kim, he/him/they/them

Term	Definition
Gender expression/ presentation	How someone expresses their gender. This can include clothing, mannerisms, make-up, and communication styles. May not indicate someone is TGD, as cisgender people can also express their gender in ways that do not follow societal expectations.
Genderfluid	Someone’s sense of gender moves across the multiple genders the person identifies with, for example femme ↔ non-binary which can occur over any timeframe (hours, days, months etc).
Genderflux	A person who’s connection to their sense of gender/gender identity fluctuates in intensity over time.
Gender identity	The internal feeling that someone has of their own gender (or lack of). Someone’s gender identity is not visible to others and may or may not align with what they were assigned to at birth.
Gender neutral	A term used to refer to someone who is neither male or female but is genderless (it can also be another term for Agender).
Gender neutral language	Words or terms that are used that do not imply any gender eg. a gender neutral term is “Staffed”, rather than “Manned”. This can be used to be inclusive of Trans, Gender Diverse and Nonbinary communities.
Gender non- conforming	People who don’t conform to gender stereotypes or norms and differ from their culture’s/society’s expectations of masculine or feminine people. Also appears as GNC.
Gender norms	The expectations for how people should or shouldn’t think or behave in society and how others should treat them according to their gender. These expectations can vary from culture to culture.
Genderqueer	A term used by people who identify outside of the traditional gender binary.
Intersectionality	The interconnected nature of social categorisations such as race, class, and gender, which can create overlapping and interdependent systems of discrimination or disadvantage.
Intersex	People who are born with sex characteristics that do not fit medically expected norms for female or male bodies. It is not the same as being Trans or Gender Diverse.

Term	Definition
LGBTQIA+	An acronym that represents sexual and gender minorities that stands for lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, queer, intersex, asexual/aromantic with the + representing other gender identities/sexualities that are part of the community.
Misgendering	The act of referring to or addressing someone using language that does not correctly reflect their gender identity.
NB/Enby	A shorthand way of saying Nonbinary, which is described below.
Neo-pronouns	Literally translates to “new pronouns”, these are pronouns used as an alternative to the more common pronouns (she/her, they/them, he/him) as another way to express/ represent one’s gender identity. Examples of these neopronouns are Xe/Xem/Xers, Ze/Hir/Hirs, and E/Em/Eirs.
Nonbinary	A term used by people who don't identify exclusively as male or female. They may identify as a gender in between, a mixture of male and female or something completely outside men and women.
Pronouns	Words used to refer to someone in the third person (e.g., he/him, she/her, they/them).
Pangender	A term used by people that experience many or all genders as part of their identity. They may experience each gender one at a time or simultaneously.
QTIBIPOC	An acronym that stands for queer, trans, intersex, black, indigenous people of colour. A way to highlight the existence, involvement and importance of black, indigenous and other people of colour in TGD communities.
Queer	An umbrella term used by some people to describe their non-heteronormative sexual orientation or gender identity, often reclaimed as an inclusive and affirming term.
Sex (activity)	When people engage in sexual activity that can involve multiple sexual organs, body parts and/or objects.

Term	Definition
Sex (biological)	Something that is assigned to a person at birth by a medical professional, used to categorise people depending on their biological makeup. (Different to gender and gender expression)
Sexual orientation	It describes a person's sexual, romantic and/or emotional attraction towards other people.
Sexuality	An integral part of the human experience encompassing sex, gender identities and roles, sexual orientation, eroticism, intimacy, and reproduction, influenced by the complex interplay of biological, psychological, social, cultural, and other factors.
Sistergirl	A term used by Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people to describe those who are gender diverse that have a female spirit. They take on female roles within the community and have a strong connection to their culture. Nonbinary people may also connect to a Sistergirl if they embody a feminine spirit.
TGD	An acronym for “transgender and gender diverse”
TGDNB	An acronym that stands for “trans, gender diverse and nonbinary”. It is a way to group all gender diverse experiences together.
Trans masculine	A person who does not feel like a (trans) ‘man’, but still experiences their gender as being masculine.
Trans feminine	A person who does not feel like a (trans) ‘woman’, but still experiences their gender as being feminine.
Transgender	A term used to describe people whose gender identity differs from the sex assigned to them at birth.
Transmob	A term that Aboriginal and Torres Strait Island people use to describe trans and gender diverse people in their communities.
Transphobia	Discrimination or prejudice against TGD people.



supporting your gender journey

Transgender Victoria is Victoria's leading body for transgender and gender diverse people.

We are trans-led, working for, by and with trans communities to achieve better social, economic and health outcomes. We represent trans communities by fostering connection, advocating for change and supporting trans people to lead full and meaningful lives.

What we do:

Affirmation Station

Affirmation Station is Melbourne's trans-led community hub where trans and gender diverse people can connect with other TGD people, explore their identity, and find the support they need on your gender journey.

Peer Navigation

Peer Navigation is for those looking for a supportive and confidential space to explore their gender. We can help you understand service options and answer your questions in practical, easy-to-understand ways. Transgender Victoria offers free Peer Navigation sessions for anyone in Victoria.

Events

We run regular events throughout the year for trans and gender diverse people. We offer a diverse range of programs, workshops, and gatherings that foster connection, build community, and provide a safe enough space for trans and gender diverse people to celebrate their identity.

Training

We offer industry-leading training on trans and gender diverse and LGBTIQ+ inclusion and service provision, available online or in person.